

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

NEED FOR SPEED
A Shatabdi Express train; (inset) Madhavrao Scindia, who championed the concept as railway minister in the late '80s



49th ANNIVERSARY

TURNING POINTS
INFRASTRUCTURE

THE SHATABDI, 1988

The Superfast Success

The Shatabdi Express redefined Indian rail travel, blending speed and luxury, and laid the foundation for modern innovations like the Vande Bharat Express

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Before July 10, 1988, the idea of business-class train travel was alien to most Indians. Train journeys were largely utilitarian, and long-distance premium travel was dominated by the Rajdhani Express, launched about two decades prior and connecting the national capital to Calcutta and Bombay at the time. All other trains made way for its passage, reinforcing its status as the pinnacle of Indian Railways.

Then came the Shatabdi Express in 1988, breaking the mould and redefining rail travel. Designed as a point-to-point service with minimal stops, it achieved a top speed of 150 kmph, making it the fastest train in India. Modelled after air travel, it featured plush reclining seats and onboard meals served by stewards, all included in the ticket price. The Shatabdi was a glimpse into the future, prioritising speed, comfort and efficiency while maintaining operational precedence.

Launched during the Rajiv Gandhi era, the Shatabdi was named to commemorate his grandfather and India's first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru's